

CIVIL RIGHTS LEADER Born 1929 Died 1968

Martin Luther King

“Our lives begin to end **the day we become silent** about things that matter.”

MARTIN LUTHER KING JR.

Martin Luther King Jr. was born into a family committed to the struggle for civil rights (see pp.434–35). Both his father and his grandfather were preachers who had spoken out against the denial of rights black people were subjected to in the US. As a student, he became familiar with the ideas of nonviolent protest of Mohandas Gandhi (see pp.408–09). What King knew of Gandhi chimed with his Christian faith; he once said, “I went to Gandhi through Jesus.” King came to believe that by suffering violence without responding in kind, campaigners might build up an

irresistible moral force for change. King was recently married and newly established as a Baptist pastor in Montgomery, Alabama, when the Montgomery Bus Boycott, protesting against segregation on the city transit system, propelled him onto the national stage. King did not start the

A gift for eloquence

Martin Luther King's personal courage, eloquence as a public speaker, and unswerving dedication to nonviolence made a vital contribution to the progress achieved by the civil rights movement in the US in the 1950s and 1960s.

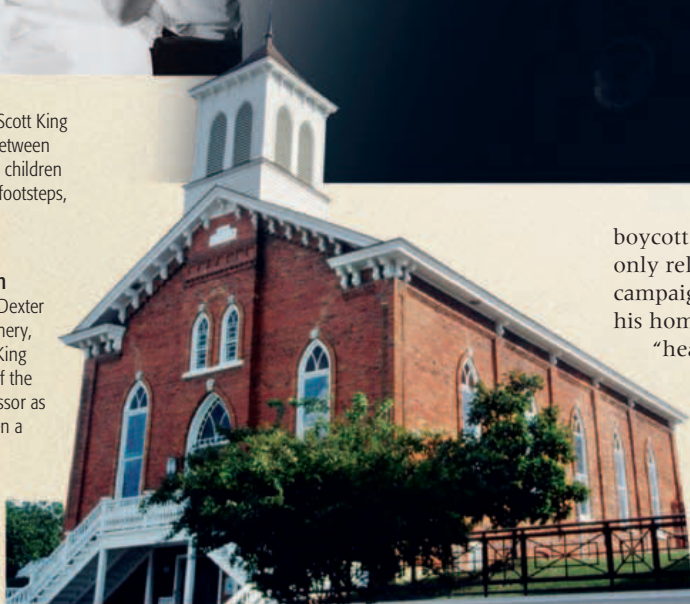


The King family

Martin Luther King Jr. and Coretta Scott King had two sons and two daughters between 1955 and 1963. All four of the King children grew up to follow in their parents' footsteps, becoming civil rights activists.

Dexter Avenue Baptist Church

It was during his time as pastor of Dexter Avenue Baptist Church in Montgomery, Alabama, from 1954 to 1960, that King became an acknowledged leader of the civil rights movement. His predecessor as pastor, Vernon Johns, had also been a tireless campaigner against racial discrimination.



boycott in December 1955 and only reluctantly agreed to lead the campaign. He nearly pulled out when his home was bombed, but said he “heard the voice of Jesus saying still to fight on.” When the boycott was shown on national TV, King's speeches and great dignity had an immediate impact. In 1957 the Southern Christian Leadership Conference (SCLC) was formed to build on the

success of the Montgomery Bus Boycott. King became the leader of the SCLC, which was a more radical alternative to the long-established National Association for the Advancement of Colored People (NAACP). While unswerving in his commitment to nonviolence, King was prepared to pursue civil disobedience energetically, breaking laws he considered unjust and provoking confrontation with racist authorities and the police. He did not then, or later, control the civil rights movement,

